To Hell with Dying

By Alice Walker

INTRODUCTION

Our society is more generationally stratified than ever before, making the elderly feel particularly alienated. According to one study from the University of California San Francisco, 43% of seniors report feeling lonely, which comes with a staggering 59% higher risk of declining health and a 45% higher risk of death. In short, the epidemic of loneliness among the elderly isn't just an emotional travesty, it's a health hazard.

*But love can **always** defeat loneliness. It can give those who are struggling a reason to live when the feeling of defeat is overpowering. Never underestimate the healing power of love.*

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"To hell with dying," my father would say. "These children want Mr. Sweet!" Mr. Sweet was a diabetic and an alcoholic and a guitar player and lived down the road from us on a neglected cotton farm. "To hell with dying, man," "These children want Mr. Sweet!" At a signal from Father they would come crowding around the bed and throw themselves on the covers, and whoever was the smallest at the time would kiss him all over his wrinkled brown face and tickle him so that he would laugh all down in his stomach, and his mustache, which was long and sort of straggly, would shake like Spanish moss.

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Mr. Sweet had been ambitious as a boy, wanted to be a doctor or lawyer or sailor, only to find that black men fare better if they are not. Since he could become none of these things he turned to fishing as his only earnest career and playing the guitar as his only claim to doing anything extraordinarily well.

Mr. Sweet used to call me his princess, and I believed it. He made me feel pretty at five and six, and simply outrageously devastating at the blazing age of eight and a half. When he came to our house with his guitar the whole family would stop whatever they were doing to sit around him and listen to him play. He liked to play "Sweet Georgia Brown," and all sorts of sweet, sad, wonderful songs. Sometimes he would cry and that was an indication that he was about to die again. And so we would all get prepared, for we were sure to be called upon.

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I was seven the first time I remember actually participating in one of Mr. Sweet's "revivals" - my parents told me I had participated before; I had been the one chosen to kiss him and tickle him long before I knew the rite of Mr. Sweet's rehabilitation. He had come to our house, it was a few years after his wife's death and he was very sad. He sat on the floor next to me and my older brother, the rest of the children were grown up and lived elsewhere, and he began to play his guitar and cry. When he was leaving, my mother said to us that we'd better sleep light that night for we'd probably have to go over to Mr. Sweet's before daylight. And we did. For soon after we had gone to bed one of the neighbors knocked on our door and called my father and said that Mr. Sweet was sinking fast and if he wanted to get in a word before the crossover, he'd better shake a leg and get over to Mr. Sweet's house. As soon as we heard the cry we got up, my brother and I and my mother and father, and put on our clothes. We hurried out of the house and down the road for we were always afraid that we might someday be too late, and Mr. Sweet would get tired of dallying.

When we got to the house, a very poor shack really, we found the front room full of neighbors and relatives and someone met us at the door and said it was all very sad that old Mr. Sweet Little was about to kick the bucket. My parents were advised not to take my brother and me into the "death room," seeing we were so young and all, but we dashed in without giving his warning a second thought. I was almost in tears, for these deaths upset me fearfully, and the thought of how much depended on me and my brother made me very nervous.

The doctor was bending over the bed and turned back to tell us for at least the tenth time in the history of my family, that, alas, old Mr. Sweet Little was dying and that children had best not see the face of implacable. My father pushed him rather abruptly out of the way saying, as he always did and very loudly for he was saying it to Mr. Sweet, "To hell with dying, man, these children want Mr. Sweet" - which was my cue to throw myself upon the bed and kiss Mr. Sweet under the eyes and around the collar of his nightshirt where he smelled so strongly of all sorts of things, mostly liniment. I was very good at bringing him around, for as soon as I saw that he was struggling to open his eyes I knew

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he was going to be all right.

Once, though, I got a tremendous scare, for he could not open his eyes and later I learned that he had had a stroke and that one side of his face was stiff and hard to get into motion. When he began to smile, I could tickle him in earnest because I was sure that nothing would get in the way of his laughter.

When we were sure he would listen to us, we would ask him why he was in bed and when he was coming to see us again and could we play his guitar, which more than likely would be leaning against the bed. His eyes would get all misty and he would sometimes cry out loud, but we never let it embarrass us, for he knew that we loved him.

My brother was very generous in all this, he let me do all the revival-ing - he had done it for years before I was born and so he was glad to be able to pass it on to someone new. What he would do while I talked to Mr. Sweet was pretend to play the guitar, in fact he pretended that he was a young version of Mr. Sweet, and it always made Mr. Sweet glad to think that someone wanted to be like him.

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We were desperately afraid that he was just going to take off one day and leave us.

It did not occur to us that we were doing anything special; we had not learned that death was final when it did come. We thought nothing of triumphing over it so many times, and in fact became a trifle contemptuous of people who let themselves be carried away. It did not occur to us that if our father had been dying we could not have stopped it, that Mr. Sweet was the only person over whom we had power.

When Mr. Sweet was in his eighties, I was studying in the university many miles from home. By this time, he not only had a mustache but a long flowing snow-white beard, which I combed and braided. He was very peaceful, fragile, gentle, and the only jarring note about him was his old steel guitar, which he still played in the old sad, sweet, down-home blues way.

On Mr. Sweets ninetieth birthday I was finishing my doctorate in Massachusetts. That morning I got a telegram telling me that Mr. Sweet was dying again and could I

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please drop everything and come home. Of course, I could. My dissertation could wait. Within hours I was speeding along the dusty road to Mr. Sweet's.

The house was more dilapidated than when I was last there, barely a shack, but it was overgrown with yellow roses, which my family had planted many years ago. The air was heavy and sweet and very peaceful. I felt strange walking through the gate and up the old rickety steps. But the strangeness left me as I caught sight of the long white beard flowing down the thin body over the familiar quilt coverlet. Mr. Sweet!

His eyes were closed tight and his hands, crossed over his stomach, were thin and delicate. I looked around at my parents and was surprised to see that my father and mother also looked old and frail. My father, his own hair very gray, leaned over the quietly sleeping old man, who, incidentally, smelled still of wine and tobacco, and said, as he'd done so many times, "To hell with dying, man! My daughter is home to see Mr. Sweet!" I bent down and gently stroked the closed eyes and gradually they began to open. The closed lips twitched a little, then parted in a

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warm, slightly embarrassed smile. Mr. Sweet could see me and he recognized me and his eyes looked very spry and twinkly for a moment. I put my head down on the pillow next to his and we just looked at each other for a long time. He began to trace my hair line with a thin, smooth finger. I closed my eyes when his finger halted above my ear. His hand stayed cupped around my cheek. When I opened my eyes, sure that I had reached him in time, his were closed.

Even at twenty-four how could I believe that I had failed? That Mr. Sweet was really gone? But when I looked at my parents, I saw that they were holding back tears. They had loved him dearly. He was like a piece of rare and delicate china which was always being saved from breaking and which finally fell. I looked long at the old face, the wrinkled forehead, the hands that still reached out to me. Soon I felt my father pushing something cool into my hands. It was Mr. Sweet's guitar. He had asked them months before to give it to me; he had known that even if I came next time, he would not be able to respond in the old way. He did not want me to feel that my trip had been for nothing.

The old guitar! I plucked the strings *(*humming "Sweet*

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Georgia Brown") The magic of Mr. Sweet lingered still in the cold steel box. Through the window I could catch the fragrant delicate scent of tender yellow roses. The man on the high old-fashioned bed with the quilt coverlet and the flowing white beard had been my first love.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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Sweet Georgia Brown
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2a07JsE6dOU

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